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CUET UG

History

Religious History: Bhakti-Sufi Traditions

Themes in Indian History (Part II) · Theme 6 · Class 12

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Aligned to the latest official syllabus · Concept-first explanations

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA History 314)	Skills the questions test
Integration of Cults	Great vs Little traditions, Jagannatha cult of Puri (tribal wooden image), Goddess worship, Tantric anti-varna practices	Anthropological concepts, syncretism, iconographic analysis
Alvars & Nayanars	Tamil devotional poets (Vishnu vs Shiva), rejection of caste orthodoxy, **Nalayira Divyaprabandham** ("Tamil Veda"), **Tevaram**, Andal and Karaikkal Ammaiyar	Textual canons, gender in early medieval religion, Chola temple patronage
Virashaivas / Lingayats	Basavanna (Kalachuri minister), Lingayat identity (wearing silver linga), rejection of caste, pollution, rebirth, child marriage, burial practices, Kannada **Vachanas**	Radical socio-religious reform, epigraphic and textual history
Sufi Silsilas & Khanqahs	Asceticism in Islam (**Tasawwuf**), unbroken chains (**silsilas**), Chishti masters (Muinuddin Chishti, Nizamuddin Auliya, Baba Farid), **khanqah** life, **langar**, **sama'**, **ziyarat**	Institutional history, Sufi literature, state-Sufi relations
Northern Sants	Nirguna vs Saguna bhakti; Kabir (weaver of Varanasi, **Ulatbansi**, **Bijak**); Baba Guru Nanak (**Nirankar**, **Shabad**, **Langar**, **Adi Granth**); Mirabai (**Giridhar Gopal**, guru Raidas)	Comparative devotional philosophy, subaltern resistance, textual compilations

CUET Strategy & Exam Reality

- **Core Exam Pointers:** CUET UG frequently tests exact details: the title of the Alvars' collection (**Nalayira Divyaprabandham**, 4,000 verses, known as the **Tamil Veda**); the female saints (**Andal** who saw herself as the bride of Vishnu, **Karaikkal Ammaiyar** who adopted a skeletal form for Shiva); the founder of the Lingayats (**Basavanna**); the chronological order of the five major Chishti saints; the concept of **Ulatbansi** in Kabir's poetry; and the distinction between **Saguna** (with form/attributes) and **Nirguna** (without form/attributes) bhakti.
- **Analytical Perspective:** Questions challenge candidates to trace how devotional movements utilized vernacular languages to bypass Brahmanical Sanskrit monopoly and challenge hereditary caste barriers.

1. The Mosaic of Religious Beliefs: Integration of Cults

Historians studying the period from the 8th to the 18th century observe a remarkable proliferation of diverse religious beliefs and practices across the subcontinent.

Two Interconnected Cultural Processes

Sociologist Robert Redfield coined the concepts of the **Great Tradition** (elite, literate, pan-Indian textual rituals) and the **Little Tradition** (localized, peasant, folk customs). In medieval India, these two traditions engaged in constant dialogue through two primary processes:

1. **Dissemination of Brahmanical Ideas:** Brahmanas composed and circulated accessible Sanskrit texts, especially the **Puranas**. Written in simple couplets, the Puranas were meant to be recited aloud and heard by women and Shudras, who were traditionally excluded from reading the Vedas.
2. **Assimilation of Local and Tribal Deities:** Brahmanas adopted, modified, and integrated local folk cults into the high pantheon:
   - **The Cult of Jagannatha at Puri (Odisha):** Literally "Lord of the World", Jagannatha was originally a local tribal deity worshipped as a crude wooden image carved from a log. By the 12th century, he was formally identified as an incarnation of Vishnu and integrated into a major temple cult alongside his brother Balabhadra and sister Subhadra.
   - **Goddess Cults:** Local deities—often worshipped simply as stones smeared with vermilion (**ochre**)—were incorporated into the Puranic framework as the consorts of major male gods: Lakshmi as the consort of Vishnu, and Parvati (or Kali/Durga) as the consort of Shiva.

The Tantric Challenge

Parallel to Puranic worship was the widespread emergence of **Tantric practices**:

- **Universal Accessibility:** Tantric rites were open to all individuals regardless of gender, caste, or varna status.
- **Rejection of Orthodoxy:** Tantric practitioners openly rejected the authority of the Vedas, dismissed caste hierarchies, and focused on invoking female cosmic energy (**Shakti**).
- **Cross-Tradition Influence:** Tantric ideas deeply influenced Shaivism, Vaishnavism, and medieval Vajrayana Buddhism.

2. The Early Bhakti Movements in South India: Alvars and Nayanars

Around the 6th century CE, the earliest organized Bhakti movements emerged in the Tamil-speaking regions of southern India, led by saint-poets who traveled from village to village singing emotional hymns of praise:

- **Alvars:** Literally "those who are immersed" in deep devotion to the god **Vishnu**.
- **Nayanars:** Literally "leaders" or guides who were devotees of the god **Shiva**.

Opposition to Religious Orthodoxy and Rival Traditions

The Alvars and Nayanars mounted a passionate critique of two dominant religious establishments:

1. **Critique of Caste and Brahmanical Exclusivism:** They welcomed untouchables, artisans, cultivators (**Vellalas**), and women into their ranks. The Alvar saint **Tondaradippodi**, a Brahmana, famously declared that even outcastes who loved Vishnu were superior to learned Brahmanas who lacked devotion.
2. **Rivalry with Buddhism and Jainism:** The Tamil Bhakti saints actively opposed the monastic austerity of Buddhists and Jains, who enjoyed substantial patronage in early medieval south Indian courts. Hymns in the **Tevaram** contain sharp polemics against Jain ascetics.

Women Devotees: Andal and Karaikkal Ammaiyar

One of the most striking features of the southern Bhakti movement was the prominent presence of women who renounced traditional domestic expectations:

- **Andal:** The only female Alvar among the twelve Alvars. Andal expressed her passionate love for Vishnu through ecstatic bridal poetry (**Tiruppavai**), declaring that she would marry only the deity Ranganatha of Srirangam. Her verses continue to be recited across Tamil temples today.
- **Karaikkal Ammaiyar:** A celebrated female Nayanar from the port town of Karaikkal. Renouncing her conventional wifehood, wealth, and physical beauty, she prayed to Shiva to strip away her youthful feminine flesh, transforming her into an emaciated, skeletal ascetic demoness (**pey**) to sit forever at the feet of dancing Shiva.

Textual Canons and Royal Chola Patronage

- **Nalayira Divyaprabandham:** The foundational scripture of the Alvars, compiling 4,000 Tamil hymns composed by the twelve Alvars, compiled in the 10th century by Nathamuni. It was revered as the **Tamil Veda**, claiming equal sacred status to the four Sanskrit Vedas.
- **Tevaram:** The revered collection of Nayanar hymns composed by the three great poets **Appar**, **Sambandar**, and **Sundarar**, compiled by Nambiyandar Nambi.
- **Imperial Chola Temple Patronage:** From the 9th to the 13th century, Chola emperors (such as **Parantaka I** and **Rajaraja I**) actively patronized Tamil Bhakti to legitimize their imperial sovereignty:
  - Built colossal stone temples at **Thanjavur**, **Gangaikondacholapuram**, and **Chidambaram**.
  - Commissioned magnificent bronze sculptures of **Shiva Nataraja** (the Lord of Dance) and bronze likenesses of the Nayanar saints, carrying them in public religious processions.

3. The Virashaiva Tradition in Karnataka

In the 12th century, a revolutionary devotional movement erupted in northern Karnataka, led by a Brahmana minister named **Basavanna** (1106–1167 CE) in the court of the Kalachuri ruler Bijjala:



Figure 1: Figure 1: Comparative Quadrant Matrix of Devotional Streams: Alvars/Nayanars, Karnataka Virashaivas, Northern Nirguna, and Saguna Traditions.

- **Terminology:** Followers were known as **Virashaivas** ("heroes of Shiva") or **Lingayats** ("wearers of the linga").
- **The Sacred Emblem:** Lingayats worshipped Shiva exclusively in his manifestation as a **linga**. Adult men and women wore a small silver box containing a miniature stone linga looped over their left shoulder.
- **Radical Social Ruptures:**
  - **Rejection of Caste & Pollution:** Basavanna fiercely denounced the four-fold varna hierarchy, untouchability, and the Brahmanical concept of ritual pollution associated with menstruation, birth, and death.
  - **Rejection of Rebirth:** Lingayats believed that upon death, the devout devotee merges directly and irrevocably with Shiva and is never reborn into the cycle of samsara.
  - **Burial Instead of Cremation:** Because the soul united directly with Shiva, Lingayats did not cremate their dead, but buried them peacefully in a sitting meditative posture, discarding all orthodox Brahmanical post-death funeral rites (**shraddha**).
  - **Rejection of Child Marriage:** They encouraged adult consensual marriage and permitted the remarriage of widows (**kudike**), defying Dharmashastric prohibitions.
- **Vachana Literature:** The teachings of the movement were composed in brief, pithy, rhythmic Kannada prose-poems known as **Vachanas** ("sayings"), authored by Basavanna, the mystic **Allama Prabhu**, and the intrepid female poet-saint **Akka Mahadevi**, who renounced all clothing and wandered naked in spiritual devotion to Shiva (**Chennamallikarjuna**).

4. Religious Ferment in North India: Naths, Jogis, and the Islamic Encounter

During the early medieval period in northern India, orthodox Brahmanical authority was challenged by non-conformist wandering ascetic groups known as **Naths**, **Jogis**, and **Siddhas**:

- **Hatha Yoga and Alchemy:** They came from artisanal craft backgrounds (potters, weavers) and rejected caste hierarchies, sacrificial rituals, and Vedic scriptures, seeking immortality through breathing control (**pranayama**), physical postures (**hatha yoga**), and esoteric alchemy.
- **Vernacular Poetry:** They expressed their unconventional teachings in the common vernacular tongue (**Sant Bhasha** or early Hindi), establishing a popular culture of dissent.

The Delhi Sultanate and Islamic Governance

The establishment of the Delhi Sultanate in the 13th century introduced Islamic political and legal structures into northern India:

- **Shari'a:** The sacred law governing the Muslim community based on the **Quran** and **Hadith** (traditions of Prophet Muhammad).
- **Ulama:** Learned theologians, jurists, and scholars of Islamic law who served as judges (**qazis**), teachers, and advisers, urging rulers to enforce orthodox Islamic governance.
- **The Zimmi Category:** Because the vast majority of the Indian population was non-Muslim, rulers could not enforce strict Islamic orthodoxy. They classified Hindu subjects as **Zimmis** ("protected people"):
  - Non-Muslim subjects paid a poll tax known as the **Jizya**.
  - In return, they were granted complete freedom to practice their religion, manage internal caste disputes, and receive state protection.
  - Rulers regularly endowed Hindu temples, granted tax-free lands (**inams**), and attended popular festivals.

5. Sufism: Philosophy, Khanqahs, and Silsilas

In the early centuries of Islam, a group of religious mystics turned toward asceticism and contemplation in protest against the growing materialism and worldly decadence of the Umayyad and Abbasid Caliphates. They became known as **Sufis** (practitioners of **Tasawwuf**):

- **Love and Devotion (Ishq):** Sufis rejected rigid scholastic legalism, emphasizing intense, unconditional love (**ishq**) and ecstatic emotional longing for union with God.
- **The Khanqah (Hospice):** By the 11th century, Sufism was institutionalized in hospices known as **khanqahs**. A khanqah was presided over by a spiritual master known as a **Shaikh**, **Pir**, or **Murshid**, who enrolled disciples (**murids**) and appointed spiritual successors (**khalifas**).

The Concept of the Silsila



Figure 2: Figure 2: The Chishti Sufi Silsila & Khanqah Ecosystem: Spiritual Lineage Tree and Institutional Organization.

- **Silsila (Chain):** Literally signifies a continuous spiritual chain or genealogy linking the disciple through his master in an unbroken lineage back to Ali and the Prophet Muhammad.
- **Two Streams:**
  - **Ba-shari'a:** Sufi orders that observed the Islamic legal code (**shari'a**) while practicing mysticism (e.g., Chishtis, Suhrawardis, Naqshbandis).
  - **Be-shari'a:** Wandering antinomian dervishes who ignored external legal conventions, practiced extreme asceticism, and begged for alms (e.g., **Qalandars**, **Madaris**, **Malangs**).

The Chishti Order in the Subcontinent

The **Chishti Silsila**, originating in the town of Chisht in western Afghanistan, was introduced to India in 1192 CE by **Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti**:

1. **Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti** (Gharib Nawaz **- "Protector of the Poor", d. 1235 CE):** Established his hospice at **Ajmer** (Rajasthan), strategically situated along trade routes connecting Delhi to Gujarat. His shrine became the premier pilgrimage center of northern India, famously visited fourteen times on foot by Mughal Emperor **Akbar**, who funded the construction of two massive cooking cauldrons (**degs**).
2. **Khwaja Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki (d. 1235 CE):** Successor who established the Chishti hospice in Mehrauli, Delhi; the celebrated **Qutb Minar** was named to commemorate him.
3. **Shaikh Fariduddin Ganj-i Shakar** (Baba Farid**, d. 1265 CE):** Set up his hospice at **Ajodhan** (Pakpattan, Punjab). Baba Farid composed mystical devotional hymns in local

Punjabi, which were so revered that Guru Arjan Dev incorporated them into the sacred Sikh scripture, the **Guru Granth Sahib**.

4. **Shaikh Nizamuddin Auliya (**Sultan-ul-Mashaikh**, d. 1325 CE):** Presided over the golden age of the Chishti order from his hospice in **Ghiyaspur** (Delhi). His open-door policy attracted thousands of commoners, princes, and scholars, including the celebrated court poet **Amir Khusrau**.
5. **Shaikh Nasiruddin Mahmud (**Chiragh-i Dehli **- "The Lamp of Delhi", d. 1356 CE):** Preserved the ascetic integrity of the order following the disruptive policies of Muhammad bin Tughlaq.

Daily Life in the Chishti Khanqah

- **Communal Langar:** A large community kitchen operated daily, feeding hundreds of poor mendicants, travelers, and nobles. The langar ran exclusively on unsolicited charitable offerings (**futuh**), with the strict rule that all food must be distributed before nightfall without saving for the morrow.
- **Sama' (Musical Audition):** Music was central to Chishti spiritual practice. Sufi assemblies convened for **sama'**, where professional musicians (**qawwals**) recited mystical verses. The spiritual ecstasy (**wajd**) induced by melody was viewed as a divine vehicle to awaken love for God.
- **Ziyarat and Urs:** Devotees undertook pilgrimage (**ziyarat**) to the tomb (**dargah**) of a deceased saint, seeking his spiritual intercession (**barakat**). The annual death anniversary of the saint was celebrated as the **Urs** (literally "mystical marriage"), signifying the joyous union of the saint's soul with the Divine Beloved.

Vernacular Literature and Syncretic Traditions

Sufis deliberately integrated into regional linguistic cultures:

- **Premakhyans (Allegorical Love Romances):** Sufi poets composed exquisite allegorical romances in local **Awadhi** and Hindavi. The most celebrated is **Malik Muhammad Jayasi's Padmavat** (c. 1540 CE), where the romantic quest of King Ratansen for Princess Padmavati of Chittor symbolized the soul's arduous spiritual journey toward divine truth.
- **Lurinama and Charkhanama:** In the Deccan (Bijapur), Sufis composed short devotional songs in **Dakhani** set to traditional rhythms, sung by village women while grinding grain at the stone mill (**chakkinama**) or rocking babies in cradles (**lurinama**).

6. New Devotional Paths in Northern India: Kabir, Guru Nanak, and Mirabai



Figure 3: Figure 3: Comprehensive Topic Map & Architectural Framework of Bhakti-Sufi Religious Traditions (c. 8th – 18th Century CE).

During the 15th and 16th centuries, northern India witnessed the flowering of powerful vernacular Sant movements that fundamentally reshaped popular religious consciousness.

Kabir: The Monotheistic Weaver of Varanasi

Kabir (c. 14th–15th century) was raised in a family of Muslim weavers (**julahas**) settled in Varanasi:

- **Theological Synthesis:** Kabir synthesized Hindu and Islamic concepts of the Divine, addressing the Supreme Being through diverse names: **Allah**, **Khuda**, **Hazrat**, **Pir**, **Rama**, **Hari**, **Govinda**, and **Shunya** (the mystical void).
- **Fierce Attack on Orthodoxy:** He ridiculed both Brahmanical ritualism (caste distinctions, sacred threads, temple idolatry, ritual bathing) and Islamic orthodoxy (external prayers, fasting, animal slaughter, circumcision).
- **Ulatbansi (Upside-Down Poetry):** Kabir composed striking paradoxical verses designed to shock the mind out of conventional dogmas (e.g., "the ocean is caught in a drop", "the lotus blooms without root", "the hare eats the lion").
- **Literary Compilations:** Kabir's verses are preserved across three major textual traditions:
  1. **Kabir Bijak:** Preserved by the Kabirpanth in Varanasi and eastern Uttar Pradesh.
  2. **Kabir Granthavali:** Associated with the Dadu Panth in Rajasthan.
  3. **The Adi Granth Sahib:** Incorporated into the sacred scripture of the Sikhs.

Baba Guru Nanak: The Formless Divine (Nirankar)

Baba Guru Nanak (1469–1539 CE) was born in a Hindu merchant family at **Nankana Sahib** (near Lahore, Punjab):

- **Nirguna Bhakti:** Preached absolute devotion to a formless, transcendent, genderless, and omnipresent God (**Nirankar**).
- **Rejection of External Forms:** Rejected sacrificial rituals, caste distinctions, ritual purifications, austerities, and image worship.
- **Shabad (The Word):** Taught that the Divine could be remembered and realized through meditative repetition of the divine Name (**Nam-simran**) through musical hymns (**shabad**) set to classical ragas, accompanied by his Muslim musician companion **Mardana** on the rabab.
- **Egalitarian Institutions:**
  - **Sangat:** Congregational assembly where disciples gathered to sing and pray as equals.
  - **Langar:** Free community kitchen where all visitors sat in identical rows (**pangat**) to eat food together regardless of caste or religion.
- **Institutional Succession & The Khalsa:**
  - Nanak appointed his loyal disciple Lehna as his successor, renaming him **Guru Angad**.
  - The fifth guru, **Guru Arjan Dev**, compiled the hymns of Guru Nanak and four succeeding gurus, alongside verses of Baba Farid, Ravidas, and Kabir, into the **Adi Granth** (1604 CE).
  - In 1699 CE, the tenth guru, **Guru Gobind Singh**, instituted the **Khalsa Panth** (community of the pure), giving Sikhs a distinct identity characterized by the **Five Ks** (**Kesh**, **Kanga**, **Kara**, **Kachera**, **Kirpan**), designating the holy scripture as the eternal living guide (**Guru Granth Sahib**).

Mirabai: The Defiant Royal Devotee of Krishna

Mirabai (c. 15th–16th century) is widely revered as the most famous woman poet-saint of northern India:

- **Royal Lineage:** Born as a Rajput princess of Merta (Rajasthan), she was married against her wishes to Prince Bhoj Raj of the royal Sisodia clan of Mewar.
- **Devotion to Krishna:** Mirabai defied the traditional roles of a royal wife, refusing to submit to her husband or in-laws. She recognized **Lord Krishna** (whom she addressed as **Giridhar Gopal**, "the lifter of the mountain") as her true divine husband and eternal lover.
- **Subversion of Caste and Patriarchy:** She defied palace seclusion, poured out her devotion in public dances before temples, and drank the cup of deadly poison sent by her angry brother-in-law unharmed. In a supreme act of social defiance, she rejected royal court Brahmanas and chose **Raidas**, an untouchable leather-worker (**chamar**), as her spiritual guru.
- **Popular Oral Legacy:** Mirabai did not establish a formal monastic sect; her passionate emotional songs (**bhajans**) were transmitted orally for centuries by peasants, women, and low-caste communities across Rajasthan and Gujarat.

High-Yield CUET UG Exam MCQs

Q1. The celebrated Tamil text 'Nalayira Divyaprabandham', often hailed as the fifth Veda or the Tamil Veda, is an anthology of 4,000 hymns composed by which group of saints?

(A) The 63 Nayanars
(B) The 12 Alvars
(C) The Virashaivas of Karnataka
(D) The Nathpanthis

Q2. Which female Alvar saint saw herself as the divine beloved bride of Lord Vishnu, composing passionate devotional verses that remain central to Tamil temple rituals?

(A) Karaikkal Ammaiyar
(B) Andal
(C) Akka Mahadevi
(D) Mirabai

Q3. Who was the 12th-century Brahmana minister in the Kalachuri court who spearheaded the radical anti-caste Virashaiva (Lingayat) movement in Karnataka?

(A) Allama Prabhu
(B) Basavanna
(C) Sundarar
(D) Nathamuni

Q4. Which of the following social and religious practices was NOT advocated by the Virashaivas (Lingayats)?

(A) Wearing a small silver-encased linga looped over the left shoulder
(B) Burying their dead instead of cremating them
(C) Strict observance of Brahmanical post-death pollution rituals (shraddha)
(D) Permitting the remarriage of widows and adult marriages

Q5. Under Islamic governance in the Delhi Sultanate, non-Muslim subjects who paid a poll tax (Jizya) in exchange for religious freedom and state protection were designated as:

(A) Ulama
(B) Zimmis
(C) Khuts
(D) Muqaddams

Q6. In Sufi terminology, what does the term 'Silsila' literally signify?

(A) A royal decree granting tax-free land to a hospice
(B) A continuous spiritual chain connecting the disciple through his master to Prophet Muhammad
(C) The communal kitchen operating inside a hospice
(D) The musical audition session held by qawwals

Q7. Which Chishti Sufi master established his hospice at Ajmer in Rajasthan in 1192 CE, earning the revered title 'Gharib Nawaz' (Protector of the Poor)?

(A) Khwaja Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki
(B) Shaikh Nizamuddin Auliya
(C) Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti
(D) Shaikh Nasiruddin Chiragh-i Dehli

Q8. The Punjabi mystical hymns of which Chishti Sufi saint were incorporated into the sacred Sikh scripture, the Adi Granth Sahib, compiled by Guru Arjan Dev in 1604 CE?

(A) Shaikh Fariduddin Ganj-i Shakar (Baba Farid)
(B) Shaikh Salim Chishti
(C) Shaikh Bahauddin Zakariya
(D) Mirza Mazhar Jan-i Janan

Q9. What was the term used in Chishti khanqahs for the spiritual musical sessions where qawwals recited mystical verses to evoke divine ecstatic love (wajd)?

(A) Ziyarat
(B) Sama'
(C) Langar
(D) Futuh

Q10. Which celebrated poet and courtier was the devoted disciple of Shaikh Nizamuddin Auliya, pioneering Hindavi poetry and qawwali singing at the Ghiyaspur hospice?

(A) Ziauddin Barani
(B) Amir Khusrau
(C) Malik Muhammad Jayasi
(D) Abul Fazl

Q11. What is the term given to Kabir's enigmatic, paradoxical poems where everyday meanings are inverted (such as 'the ocean is caught in a drop')?

(A) Vachana
(B) Ulatbansi
(C) Charkhanama
(D) Premakhyan

Q12. Which of the following compilations does NOT contain the verses of the 15th-century mystic poet Kabir?

(A) Kabir Bijak
(B) Kabir Granthavali
(C) Adi Granth Sahib
(D) Nalayira Divyaprabandham

Q13. In 1699 CE, which Sikh Guru instituted the 'Khalsa Panth' (the community of the pure) and established the Five Ks as distinct markers of Sikh identity?

(A) Guru Nanak
(B) Guru Arjan Dev
(C) Guru Tegh Bahadur
(D) Guru Gobind Singh

Q14. In defying conventional royal Rajput court norms, whom did the celebrated Krishna devotee Mirabai choose as her spiritual guru?

(A) Dadu Dayal
(B) Raidas (an untouchable leather-worker)
(C) Ramananda
(D) Vallabhacharya

Q15. The epic allegorical Sufi romance 'Padmavat', featuring the spiritual quest of King Ratansen for Princess Padmavati, was composed in the Awadhi language by:

(A) Amir Khusrau
(B) Malik Muhammad Jayasi
(C) Mulla Daud
(D) Mir Taqi Mir

Solutions & Detailed Explanations

Sol. Q1. The **Nalayira Divyaprabandham** is a foundational 10th-century anthology of 4,000 Tamil hymns composed by the twelve **Alvars** (devotees of Vishnu), hailed as the Tamil Veda.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. Andal was the sole female Alvar among the twelve. Her bridal poetry (**Tiruppavai**) expressed intense love for Vishnu, whom she saw as her celestial bridegroom.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q3. Basavanna was a 12th-century Brahmana minister in the court of a Kalachuri ruler who led the Virashaiva (Lingayat) movement, rejecting caste and ritualism.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q4. Lingayats fiercely rejected Brahmanical pollution rules and **shraddha** post-death rituals. Believing the dead unite directly with Shiva, they buried their dead peacefully.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q5. Zimmis were protected non-Muslim subjects under Islamic rule who paid a poll tax (**Jizya**) to enjoy religious freedom and state security.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q6. Silsila literally means a continuous spiritual chain or genealogy connecting the Sufi master and his disciples back to the Prophet Muhammad.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q7. Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti arrived in Ajmer in 1192 CE. Renowned as Gharib Nawaz, his tomb-shrine was visited repeatedly by Sultanate and Mughal rulers, including Akbar.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q8. Hymns composed in Punjabi by the Chishti saint **Baba Farid** (Shaikh Fariduddin Ganj-i Shakar of Pakpattan) were compiled into the **Adi Granth** by Guru Arjan Dev in 1604 CE.

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q9. Sama' refers to the spiritual musical audition sessions in Chishti hospices where musical performances by qawwals evoked divine ecstasy (**wajd**).

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q10. Amir Khusrau, the celebrated poet, musician, and scholar, was the devoted disciple of Shaikh Nizamuddin Auliya, creating Hindavi verses and Persian qawwalis.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q11. Ulatbansi (upside-down sayings) are paradoxical verses composed by Kabir where ordinary linguistic conventions are inverted to point toward transcendent reality.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q12. Nalayira Divyaprabandham is a 10th-century Tamil scripture of the 12 Alvars. Kabir's verses are preserved in the **Bijak**, **Kabir Granthavali**, and the **Adi Granth**.

Answer: (D)

Sol. Q13. In 1699 CE, the tenth Guru, **Guru Gobind Singh**, founded the **Khalsa Panth**, giving Sikhs the Five Ks (**Kesh**, **Kanga**, **Kara**, **Kachera**, **Kirpan**) and martial discipline.

Answer: (D)

Sol. Q14. Mirabai defied royal Rajput court prejudices by accepting **Raidas**, a low-caste leather-worker (**chamar**), as her spiritual mentor.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q15. Malik Muhammad Jayasi composed the allegorical Sufi romance **Padmavat** in Awadhi c. 1540 CE, using the story of Padmini and Ratansen to illustrate the soul's quest for God.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic: Common CUET Traps

Common Mistake	Flawed Reasoning	Accurate Historical Fact
Confusing **Alvars** with **Nayanars**	Assuming both groups worshipped the same god.	**Alvars** were devoted exclusively to **Vishnu**; **Nayanars** were devotees of **Shiva**.
Assuming Lingayats cremated their dead	Assuming all Hindu groups practice cremation.	Lingayats **buried** their dead without post-death rituals, believing the soul united directly with Shiva without rebirth.
Believing Kabir was purely a Hindu saint	Focusing only on Kabir's references to Rama.	Kabir was raised in a Muslim weaver (**julaha**) family; his teachings drew on both Sufi monotheism and yogic/

Common Mistake	Flawed Reasoning	Accurate Historical Fact
		Bhakti traditions, rejecting sectarian orthodoxies.
Assuming Chishtis accepted state jobs	Confusing Chishtis with Suhrawardi Sufis.	Chishti saints strictly **avoided** state administrative appointments, whereas Suhrawardi saints accepted state offices and royal patronage.
Thinking Mirabai founded a monastic order	Treating Mirabai like Basavanna or Guru Nanak.	Mirabai did not establish a formal sect or order; her verses survived as a rich, spontaneous oral folk tradition sung across Rajasthan and Gujarat.

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